DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

No Room for God: Why the Body Crowds Out the Soul

Derech Hashem 4:4:9-10

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 4, end of paragraph 9 and paragraph 10 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 21 February 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

A continuation

This short recording continues the class given the same evening on Derech Hashem 4:4:9, which ended in the middle of a discussion. The Ramhal had explained that the third paragraph of Shema is said to remember the Exodus, because the slavery in Egypt was an iron crucible that refined Israel. The Rabbi had asked why suffering refines a person, and begun to answer that the less physical a person has, the more he can focus on the spiritual.

No headspace for both

He continued: whatever you focus on in life comes at the expense of something else. If a person spends his life pursuing the material and looking after his body, it will come at the expense of spirituality. That does not mean neglecting the body. As the Rambam teaches, looking after the body and keeping in good health is important. But the more a person pursues it, the less space is left for the spiritual.

He mentioned that the Zohar at the beginning of Parashat Shemot also reads the "mortar and bricks" of the slavery in a deeper way. The point he drew from it is that the more the physical bricks wore them down, the more they were being refined spiritually.

After your heart and after your eyes

The same idea explains a verse in Shema itself: "Do not stray after your heart and after your eyes." The Gemara explains that "after your heart" is heresy and "after your eyes" is physical lust. Why are these two paired?

The explanation the Rabbi brought is that promiscuity is the most physical kind of sin. The Rambam writes that of the five senses, touch is the most embarrassing for human beings. Sight reaches far away, hearing and smell are more refined, but touch is the most physical. Sexual sins may not be the worst sins in the Torah, but they are the most physical ones, "the ones which clog your head up with physical things." When that happens, there is no space left for God.

So there is a direct connection between the pursuit of lust and the denial of God. The Rabbi recalled that the atheist writer Aldous Huxley wrote that part of his motive in trying to prove there was no God was to be free sexually, since belief brought restrictions on his relationships. "There's always that connection between heresy and sexual freedom." A participant added that the attraction of idolatry was the sexual freedom it allowed, and the Rabbi agreed. Another recalled that Israel wept in the wilderness "for their families", wanting to be free in their relationships again; the Rabbi said it is the same thing.

A lesson from the yeshivah lunch

The less a person indulges, the clearer his mind. The Rabbi remembered the heavy meat lunches in yeshivah: an hour later, back in the beit midrash, it was hard to concentrate on the Gemara while the body was busy digesting. With a light breakfast, just tea or something small, "your head's clean." A participant objected that today we are told to eat a good breakfast and that he cannot work without one; the Rabbi said that he himself used to eat after learning.

Two sides of one coin

So the third paragraph reminds us of Egypt, where we became spiritually free. Although that level was lost forty days after Sinai, its effect lives on, and saying the paragraph brings it down.

The Rabbi then resolved the apparent contradiction with the Gemara, which says the purpose of the third paragraph is the misvot. "It's the same thing." The purpose of remembering Egypt is to become refined and purified, to reach the level at which we can do the misvot properly. "It's really two sides of the same coin."

The 248 words (paragraph 10)

Paragraph 10 gives another, more general idea about all three paragraphs together. To rectify the human being and the universe through the oneness of God, there are 248 concepts. Man is a microcosm of the world, and the world too is divided into 248 parts, parallel to the 248 limbs of the body. These need to be fixed, and they are fixed through the 248 words of Shema.

That completes the paragraphs of Shema. The next class will cover the blessings before and after Shema, finishing the chapter.

Summary

- This recording continues the earlier class of the same evening on 4:4:9.
- Physical indulgence leaves no room for the spiritual; the body must be looked after, but the less we indulge, the clearer the mind.
- "After your heart" (heresy) and "after your eyes" (lust) are paired because the most physical sins push out awareness of God.
- Remembering Egypt and doing the misvot are two sides of one coin: refinement is what lets us keep the misvot properly.
- The 248 words of Shema rectify the 248 parts of man and of the world.

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